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MONMOUTH COUNTY • ACTIVE LISTENING

Listening First

Building Better Connections at Work

 Presented by Paul Ireifej — shouldcallpaul.com



Hearing vs. Listening

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One is automatic. One is a **choice** — and it changes everything.

Hearing

Sound waves hitting your ears.

Passive. Effortless. Background noise.

Result: You were physically present.

Listening

Choosing to focus, decode, and respond.

Active. Effortful. Eyes & mind on the speaker.

Result: The other person felt seen.



Common Roadblocks

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If you spot these in yourself, you're halfway to fixing them.

Rehearsing

Crafting your reply while they're still talking. You stop hearing them at word 3.

Distractions

Phone face-up. Email pings. Open laptop. The signal: *you don't matter.*

Filtering

Only hearing what you agree with — or what confirms your decision.

 **LIVE DEMO**

A Little Experiment

I need **ONE brave volunteer** — come on up here.

Tell us about something you **love** — a hobby, a trip, the best slice of pizza in Monmouth County. About **60 seconds**. No prep needed.

*We're going to learn something about **this whole room**.*

 60 seconds

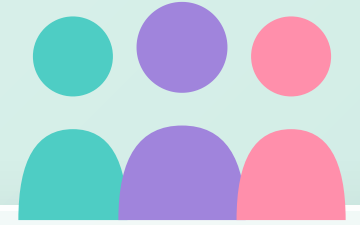
 One volunteer

 Watch what happens

Reading the Unspoken

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Words are **7%** of the message. The other **93%**? Tone, face, body.



Eyes

Looking down?
Anxious. Looking
away? Disagreeing.



Hands

Crossed arms =
guarded. Open palms =
inviting.



Tone

Same words, different
pitch — opposite
meaning.



Pauses

A long silence often
means “there’s more
here.”

The Mirror Technique

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Confirm before you respond. It saves **hours** of rework later.

1

Paraphrase

“So what I’m hearing is...”

2

Reflect Feelings

“It sounds like that was
frustrating.”

3

Confirm

“Did I get that right?”



“ People don’t want advice. They want to feel **understood** first.”



VOLUNTEER EXERCISE

The Telephone Improv

I need **ONE** brave volunteer — stand up wherever you are.

I'll start a story with one sentence. You continue with **“Yes, and...”** — *no “but,” no “however.”*

We trade lines back and forth. You can only build on what you actually **heard** me say.

We'll go until it gets weird — or until you make me laugh.

✓ Yes, and...

✗ No interrupting

😄 Have fun with it

Empathy in Action

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Step into their shoes *before* you offer your fix. The frustrated citizen on line 1 just wants to be **heard**.

✗ Without Empathy

“That’s not our department. You’ll need to call...”

Caller: shouts louder.



✓ With Empathy

“That sounds incredibly stressful — and I want to make sure you reach the right person on the first try.”

Caller: exhales.



The Power of the Pause

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Silence is not awkward — it's where **real thinking** happens. Most people quit waiting too soon.

“ Wait **3 full seconds** after they finish. The most honest words come *after* the pause.

They Process

The brain needs a beat to find the real answer.

They Add

The most useful detail usually comes after the silence.

You Calm Down

You stop reacting and start *responding*.

Better Meetings

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Active listening turns 60-minute meetings into 30-minute decisions.



1

One Voice at a Time

No talk-overs. The cost of one re-explanation? 5 minutes × 8 people.



2

Recap Before You Move

30 seconds at the end of each topic: “So we agreed...”

3

Phones Down

Lid down on laptops. Eyes up.
Stress drops, decisions speed up.



30% shorter



Better follow-through



Less burnout

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Thank You, Monmouth County!

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? Questions?

 www.shouldcallpaul.com

 shouldcallpaul@gmail.com



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